LECTURE 8

Silk Roads and Connectivities: Comparing Two Lenses

Urban Cosmopolitanism and Regional Circulation Across Asia

- **Two case studies —** *Valerie Hansen's Chang'an and Jayati Bhattacharya's Bengal-China corridor*
- **One shared question —** *how different analytical lenses change what we see as the Silk Road*

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What Is the Silk Road?

Key readings: Valerie Hansen, The Cosmopolitan Terminus of the Silk Road: Historic Chang'an, Modern-day Xi'an
- *Jayati Bhattacharya, Old Routes, New Dreams*

There is no single Silk Road narrative — there are multiple histories of connectivity.

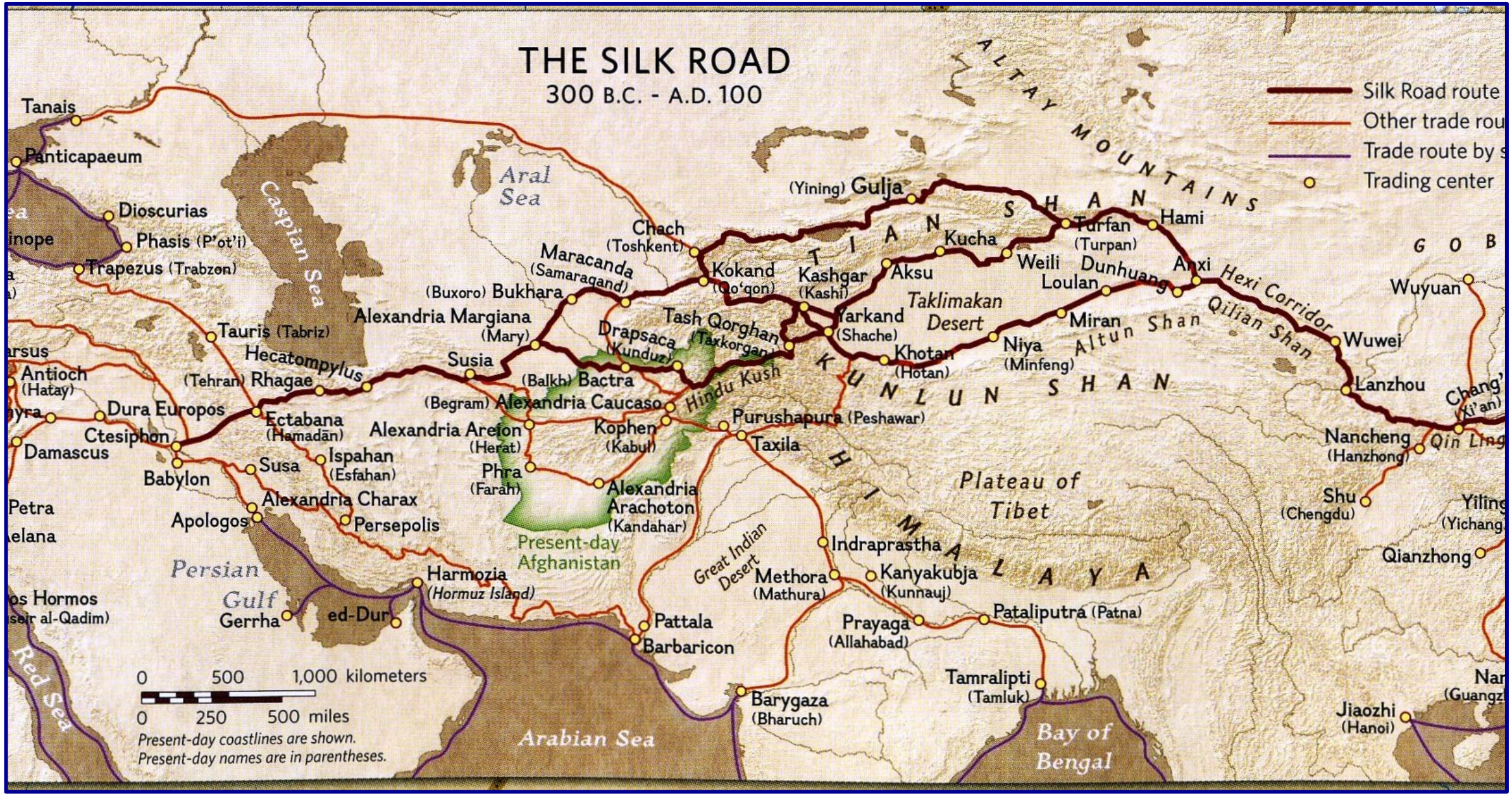
KEY POINTS

- **The popular view —** *A single overland route connecting China to the West, mainly for silk and luxury goods.*
- **What these readings show —** *Multiple routes, not one road, carrying people, religions, ideas, commodities, states, and ecologies.*
- **Different scholars, different Silk Roads —** *The lens a historian chooses shapes which Silk Road becomes visible.*
- **Key takeaway —** *Move beyond a single trade-route story toward a set of overlapping histories.*

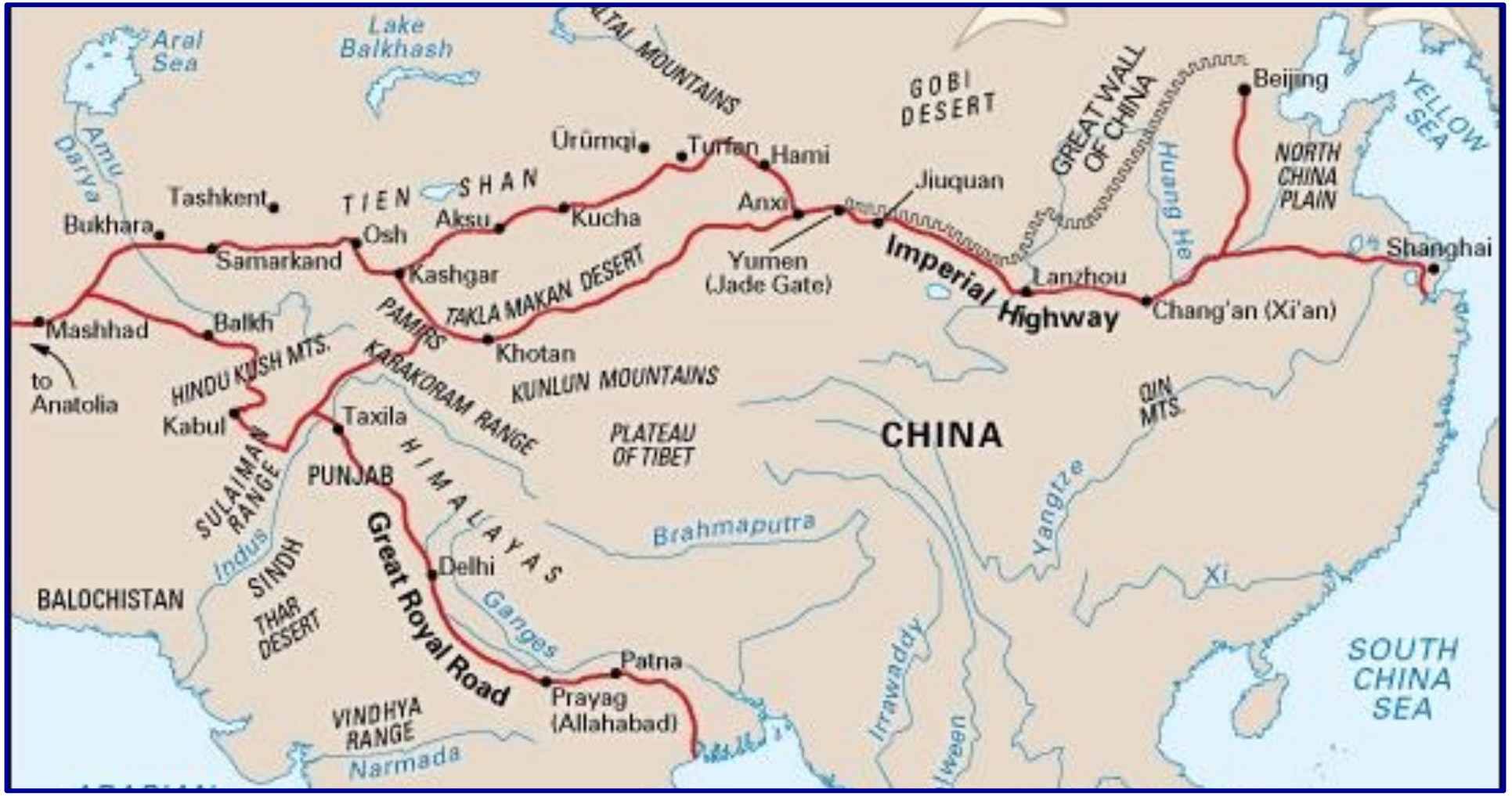
BIG QUESTION

What is the Silk Road? — the question this whole lecture keeps returning to.

The Ancient Silk Route



The Ancient Silk Route: Encyclopedia Britannica



Originating at Xian (Sian), the 4000-mile (6,400-km) road, actually a caravan tract, followed the Great Wall of China to the northwest, bypassed the Takla Makan Desert, climbed the Pamirs (mountains), crossed Afghanistan, and went on to the Levant; from there the merchandise was shipped across the Mediterranean Sea. Few persons traveled the entire route, and goods were handled in a staggered progression by middlemen. (*Encyclopedia Britannica Inc.*)

Dynamics of the Silk Road

- **Goods and commodities- Not only through trade but also through gifts and dowries (the Han rulers attempted to maintained peace by giving regular gifts of silk and lacquer ware to Hsiungnu tribes outside the Great Wall**

- **Cosmopolitan centres-**

- **Transmission of religion- Christianity, Buddhism, Manichaeism, Zoroastrianism**

- **Cultural interactions**



The Tang Dynasty Small Wild Goose Pagoda built in the Tang Dynasty in 707 AD is one of the few surviving buildings of Chang'an.
Credit: Getty Images / Adrienne Bresnahan



Silk Road exhibits at the British Museum







Objects from the National Museum of Dushanbe featuring Buddhist art from Tokharistan, circa AD 600-700; image: TCA, Stephen M. Bland

Goods Traded



EUROPE
Wool
Gold
Silver
Ivory
Jewels
Metals
Figs
Walnuts

MEDITERRANEAN
Jars

BAKU
Oil

MESOPOTAMIA
Glass

EGYPT
Glass

ARABIA
Incense

PERSIA
Dates
Pistachios
Peaches
Walnuts
Tyrian purple
Indigo
Frankincense
Myrrh
Storax
Muslin cloth
Wine
Glassware
Olive oil
Silver vessels
Glass beads
Stone beads

INDIA
Household slaves
Pets
Arena animals
Exotic furs
Cashmere
Wool
Cotton
Spinach
Sandalwood
Palm oil
Cane sugar
Perfumes
Gems
Gold
Ivory
Opium
Glass beads
Stone beads
Cinnamon

KHOTAN
Jade

TIBET
Silver
Gold

SRI LANKA
Cinnamon

SOUTHEAST ASIA
Spices
Aromatic roots
Resins

CHINA
Silk
Skins
Iron
Mirrors
Weapons
Porcelain
Lacquerware
Nephrite jade
Rhubarb
Ivory
Paper
Grain
Gunpowder
Medicines
Epsom salts
Elixirs
Ginseng
Snake bile
Seaweed
Camphor

JAPAN
Camphor

INDOCHINA
Silver
Gold
Camphor

INDONESIA
Sulphur

Cultural expressions


Dunhuang caves


Sogdian traders, fresco painting, Samarkand, Uzbekistan


Portrait of a Khotan king, Mogao, Dunhuang


Dunhuang caves


Bezeklik caves


Bezeklik caves

People on the move

- **Trade diasporas**
  - Sogdians (Iranians from Samarkand, Zerafshan river valley, modern Uzbekistan, Tazikistan)-long distance caravan trade, merchant diasporas far located far from homeland, formed part of administrative machinery
  - Muslim merchants after the decline of the Sogdians in the 8th century- resided in Chang'an and Southeastern ports of China
  - Eastern Christians (Nestorians)- Middle East to India and beyond
  - Jewish community- Repository of Hebrew documents in Cairo
  - Italian merchants- sent emissaries to Mongol Yuan dynasty
  - 17th Century onwards- dominated by Indian and Armenian merchants (horses, spices)

- **Religious missionaries**
  - Indian Buddhist monks Kasyapa Matanga and Dharmaraksa/ Dharmaratna went to China at the invitation of the Ming Emperor (57-75CE)
  - Faxian (350-414)- Travelled from Chang'an to Khotan to India- returned from Tamluk to Sri Lanka, sumatra, Guangzhou (actually reached Shandong)
  - Yijing (635-713)- Travelled from Chang'an to Yangzhou (Jiangsu), Guangzhou, Palembang, Tamluk & returned fron Tamluk, Palembang to Guangzhou- wrote about 56 monks who travelled to India, 21 through overland routes, 30 through sea routes
  - Xuangzhang- Travelled along Tarim Basin to sout to Uzbekistan & Afghanistan. On his way back, stopped at Dunhuang

PART I

Why Compare These Two Readings?

One is centered on a city, the other on a region — together they show how scale changes interpretation.

KEY POINTS

- **Hansen: city-centered —** *Chang'an and Xi'an, studied through archaeology, tombs, objects, and urban history.*
- **Bhattacharya: region-centered —** *The Bengal–Bay of Bengal–Yunnan–Himalayan zone, studied through spatial and commodity history.*
- **Different methods —** *Cosmopolitan urban life and migration, versus circulatory regions, ecology, and geopolitics.*
- **Comparison value —** *Reading them together shows how the scale of analysis reshapes the story.*

KEYPOINT

Compare urban, archaeological, and migration-based approaches with regional, ecological, and geopolitical ones.

PART I

Shared Argument Across Both Readings

Connectivity is not just movement — it is also how spaces become meaningful through movement.

KEY POINTS

- **Both reject the narrow 'silk-for-the-West' story —** *Neither treats the Silk Road as a simple linear east–west route.*
- **Both reject centers-only history —** *Imperial capitals are not the only places that matter.*
- **Both emphasise movement of people —** *Migration mattered as much as, or more than, cargo.*
- **Both emphasise cultural and political meaning —** *Religious exchange, cultural translation, and political mediation all shaped connectivity.*

SHARED POINT

Connectivity is not just movement; it is also how spaces become meaningful through movement.

Hansen: Chang'an as Cosmopolitan Terminus

Hansen shifts focus from luxury trade to urban cosmopolitanism and lived intercultural contact.

- **Not merely a Chinese capital** — *Chang'an functioned as a genuinely international hub.*
- **A hub of migrants and communities** — *Monks, merchants, craftsmen, officials, and religious communities all made their home there.*
- **Overland trade brought few bulk goods** — *Long-distance cargo volumes were smaller than popular memory suggests.*
- **People, practices, and beliefs mattered most** — *What travelled most significantly wasn't cargo, but lives and ideas.*



BEST SHORT FORMULATION

From 'luxury trade' to urban cosmopolitanism and lived intercultural contact.

PART II

Bhattacharya: Bengal and Circulatory Centrality

Bhattacharya shifts focus from 'frontier and periphery' to circulatory centrality.

- **Not peripheral, but central —** *Bengal and the northern Bay of Bengal were central to Southern Silk Road connectivities.*
- **Linked multiple worlds —** *Riverine, overland, Himalayan, and maritime zones all met here.*
- **A web of routes, not a corridor —** *The Southern Silk Road was never a single path.*
- **Modern borders obscure older connections —** *Nation-state ideas of frontier and periphery hide deeper historical ties.*



MAP 1 Centrality of Bengal in India-China connections in the northern Bay [The boundary not drawn to scale]

BEST SHORT FORMULATION

From 'frontier and periphery' to circulatory centrality.

Lens 1: The Urban Lens

The Silk Road can be studied through the history of a city, not only through routes on a map.

- **Chang'an as capital, market, and religious center —** *A single city holding many overlapping roles at once.*
- **A migrant destination —** *People arrived and stayed, creating genuinely hybrid urban culture.*
- **The Western Market and foreign communities —** *Sogdian merchants and others built a visible commercial and social presence.*
- **Elite and everyday urban life together —** *Tombs and ordinary records reveal both palace and street-level history.*

PART III

Lens 2: The Regional-Spatial Lens

The Silk Road can be studied through regions of circulation, not just empires or cities.

KEY POINTS

- **The key unit is a macro-region, not a city —** *Bengal delta, Ganges-Brahmaputra basin, Tibetan plateau, Arakan hills, Yunnan, and the Bay of Bengal.*

- **A connected space made by geography —** *Rivers, passes, ports, deltas, and caravan corridors stitched the region together.*

- **Circulation over corridor —** *Multiple overlapping paths, not a single fixed route.*

- **Scale changes the picture —** *Region-level analysis reveals connections a city-level view would miss.*

POINT TO CONSIDER

The Silk Road can be studied through regions of circulation, not just empires or cities.

PART III

Lens 3: Archaeology and Material Culture

Material culture challenges textbook myths about the Silk Road.

KEY POINTS

- **Sogdian tombs and funeral architecture —** *Funeral beds, stone houses, and epitaphs record migrant lives in detail.*
- **The Hejiacun treasure hoard (Tang Dynasty-Xian) —** *A remarkable cache revealing wealth, craftsmanship, and daily material culture.*
- **Pawnshop tickets and figurines —** *Everyday economic practice, not just grand long-distance trade.*
- **What this reveals —** *Burial hybridity, religious symbolism, and limited long-distance trade in goods.*

WHY THIS MATTERS

Objects and tombs correct the popular myth of endless caravans loaded with luxury goods.

PART III

Lens 4: Ecology and Geography

Geography is not background — it is part of the explanation.

KEY POINTS

- **River systems and mountain passes —** *Physical geography set the possible paths for movement.*
- **Deltaic environments and maritime access —** *Bengal's location linked inland and maritime Asia directly.*
- **Environmental shifts over time —** *Routes were dynamic because ecologies themselves were dynamic.*
- **Not just state policy —** *Connectivity depended on landscape as much as on rulers and treaties.*

WHY THIS MATTERS

Bengal's geography made it a hinge between inland and maritime Asia.

PART III

Lens 5: Migration and Diaspora

Silk Road history is deeply about mobile communities, not only commodities.

KEY POINTS

- **Hansen's movers —** *Sogdians, monks, officials, craftsmen, refugees, and military dependents.*
- **Bhattacharya's movers —** *Merchants, caravan traders, regional intermediaries, and diasporic communities.*
- **Later actors too —** *Colonial-era business networks and later state and strategic actors.*
- **A shared insight —** *Both readings center mobile communities, not just goods in transit.*

SHARED INSIGHT

Silk Road history is not only about commodities; it is deeply about mobile communities.

PART III

Lens 6: Religion as Connectivity

Religion did not just travel along trade routes — it often created and sustained them.

KEY POINTS

- **Hansen: multiple traditions in one city —** *Buddhism, Zoroastrianism, and Christianity all left traces in Chang'an.*
- **Monks as travelers —** *Figures like Xuanzang, Faxian, and Yijing embodied religious mobility.*
- **Bhattacharya: Buddhism across Bengal-China routes —** *Sacred geographies linked distant regions through shared belief.*
- **Cultural memory of mobility —** *Religious sites in Bengal preserve memory of older connective routes.*

POINT TO CONSIDER

Religion often created and sustained trade routes, not just travelled along them.

PART III

Lens 7: Commodities and Exchange

The two readings handle trade very differently.

KEY POINTS

- **Hansen is skeptical of inflated trade narratives —** *Long-distance overland trade favored small, high-value goods, not bulk cargo.*
- **People and ideas may have mattered more —** *Movement of migrants and beliefs likely outweighed the volume of goods.*
- **Bhattacharya traces commodity circuits —** *Cotton textiles, cowries, horses, and silver map regional systems of exchange.*
- **A key comparison —** *One reading questions the trade story; the other uses trade to reconstruct regional connectivity.*

COMPARISON

Hansen is skeptical of trade volume; Bhattacharya uses commodities to map regional systems.

The Question of Scale

City, region, empire, ocean, borderland — each gives a different Silk Road.

- **Hansen works at city scale —** *Chang'an as a single, richly documented node.*
- **Bhattacharya works at macro-regional scale —** *Bengal as a circulatory zone spanning many sub-regions.*
- **Urban archaeology versus longue durée history —** *Different methods suit different scales of analysis.*
- **The most useful historical question —** *At what scale are we studying connectivity?*

PART IV

Centre and Periphery: A Shared Critique

Centres are not natural; they are historically produced.

KEY POINTS

- **Hansen on Chang'an —** *Obviously a centre, but its cosmopolitanism depended on so-called outsiders.*
- **The centre made through interaction —** *Migrants and frontier peoples built the city's cosmopolitan character.*
- **Bhattacharya on Bengal and Yunnan —** *Labelled peripheral by later political narratives, yet historically central to exchange.*
- **The broader lesson —** *Peripheries may be highly connected spaces, not empty margins.*

BROADER LESSON

Centres are not natural; they are historically produced — and so are peripheries.

PART IV

Historical Change Over Time

Connectivity has a history that may be diverse, shifting and layered.

KEY POINTS

- **Hansen: rise and disruption —** *Chang'an's rise under the Sui and Tang, then rebellion, violence, and religious persecution.*
- **Hansen: a shift in routes —** *Movement gradually shifted from overland toward maritime paths.*
- **Bhattacharya: ancient to colonial rupture —** *Ancient and medieval circulation, then colonial rerouting and boundary-making.*
- **Bhattacharya: postcolonial revival —** *Postcolonial rupture, then selective twenty-first-century revival of old routes.*

KEY TAKEAWAY

Connectivity has a history — it expands, contracts, reroutes, and gets reimagined.

PART IV

Modern Political Uses of Silk Road History

States use Silk Road history to justify present infrastructure, diplomacy, and strategy.

KEY POINTS

- **Modern policy references —** *Act East, the Belt and Road Initiative, BCIM, and BIMSTEC all invoke older routes.*
- **New corridors, revived imaginaries —** *Historical connectivity is selectively remembered for present purposes.*
- **Most visible in Bhattacharya —** *But the critical issue applies to how any nation narrates its Silk Road past.*
- **Politically-motivated study of history—** *Politically using the past?*

DISCUSS

Are these projects reviving historical connectivity, or inventing politically useful pasts?

What Different Lenses Reveal

The Silk Road is best understood as a methodological problem, not just a historical label.

Lens	What It Helps Us See
Urban history	Cosmopolitan cities, markets, daily intercultural life
Archaeology	Migrants, burial practices, objects, lived exchange
Commodity history	Flows of goods, value, circulation systems
Religious history	Monks, sacred sites, transmission of ideas
Spatial/ecological history	Deltas, rivers, mountain passes, maritime-overland integration
Borderland studies	Regions misread as peripheral but historically central
Geopolitical lens	How the past is repurposed in the present

CONCLUSION

Different Lenses, Different Silk Roads

- **Multiple —** *Not one road, but many overlapping routes and networks.*
- **Layered —** *Made of cities, regions, migrants, objects, religions, and states all at once.*
- **Changing over time —** *Expanding, contracting, rerouting, and being reimagined across centuries.*
- **A methodological lesson —** *What we see depends entirely on the lens we choose to use.*

If Hansen teaches us to see the Silk Road through a cosmopolitan city, Bhattacharya teaches us to see it through a connected region — together, Silk Road history becomes the history of how humans created, inhabited, and reimagined networks across space.

Virtual tour of the Silk Road with Prof. Clayton Brown
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=56IzyMfLJFA